

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

The Grateful Life ~ Be Astonished

16 November 2025



Photo by Sandi Cochran

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

Childcare & Children's Programming at First Church

FCCLA offers childcare and children's programming during service for all ages — from infants through youth. For more information or to register your child, please stop by the First Kids First check-in table in the entrance to the Cathedral, or follow the signs in the hallway through the middle doors of the Sanctuary.

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions...

We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on LASST UNS ERFREUEN and BUNESSAN

Moderato and Andantino quasi allegretto in E minor from *L'Organiste* (César Franck) and Improvisation

Voluntary in G (John Stanley) and Improvisation

Praeludium in C Major (Carl August Kern) and Improvisation

Hymn To The Great Creator (Saginaw Rozzo) and Improvisation

Danse rituelle du feu (Manuel de Falla)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Claire Kelly & Juniper Fayazova

Living God,
we believe in a world made new,
where mourning is turned into dancing,
and souls are set free.

*We believe in a world where all are heard
and rivers flow where each may drink,
a world where
the harvest becomes
a banquet for all.*

God of all creation,
you have given us
a world of beauty.
You have given us a place of plenty
where no one needs to hunger...
if your people learn to share.

*Open our hearts and
teach us your compassion.
Open our minds and
grant us the courage
to count the cost.*

Give us the strength
to cast off all that
binds us to wealth and possessions.

*Guide us as we work to bring about your dream,
call us and walk with us
as we become a people
who do count the cost
to build community
and work for justice.*

[adapt/ljones]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

To You, O God, All Creatures Sing

LASST UNS ERFREUN

To you, O God, all creatures sing, and all creation, everything
Sings your praises, alleluia!
Your burning sun with golden beam, your silver moon with softer gleam
Sing your praises, alleluia, alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

Your wind that blows the tempest by, your clouds that sail across the sky
Sing your praises, alleluia!
Your morning rises with a song, and lights of evening sing along,
Sing your praises, alleluia, alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

Your flowing waters, crystal clear, make melodies for you to hear,
Sings your praises, alleluia!
Your fire,...bountiful and bright, remembering your warmth and light,
Sings your praises, alleluia, alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

To you, O God, day after day, your planet earth in every way,
Sings your praises, alleluia!
As savory fruit and fragrant flower show forth your glory and your power,
Singing praises, alleluia, alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

-text adapted by Miriam Therese Winter

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

Holy One,
in this season of thankfulness
our hearts leap with joy
at the wonder with which the world was created
and we delight in the gifts the Earth provides.

We rejoice that we can live,
move, and work amongst such beauty.
We give thanks that,
even in times when the world is filled with events that are
difficult, traumatic, life-shattering...
when we pause and remember
the deep connectedness
we have with all of creation,
even in those most difficult moments,
our hearts can well up from the depths
with gratitude.
May we be so inspired this day
with the beauty of the world in which we live and love
that we...who too often forget to give thanks,
might be stirred to living only in thanksgiving
for all the passion that life shows to us.

*This morning, O God, let our lives be turned into gifts –
to each other, to ourselves, to our world.
We pray this as thankful people.*

May it be so.
*May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!*

***Introit**

"The Road Home"
Cathedral Choir

STEPHEN PAULUS

***The Lord's Prayer**

Claire Kelly & Juniper Fayazova

*Great Spirit, our Creator, who is in all places,
Sacred is your name.
May your wisdom guide us,
Your will be done in our lives, as it is throughout Creation.*

*Provide for us today the nourishment we need,
And forgive us our wrongs, as we forgive those who have wronged us.*

*Lead us on the path of understanding and respect,
And protect us from ignorance and harm.*

*For you are the source of all power, beauty, and love,
From generation to generation, forever and always. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

Gratitude unlocks the fullness of life.
It turns what we have into enough, and more.
It turns denial into acceptance, chaos to order, confusion to clarity.
It can turn a meal into a feast, a house into a home, a stranger into a friend.
Gratitude makes sense of our past, brings peace for today, and creates a vision for tomorrow.
[Melody Beattie]

This morning, as we exchange this ancient greeting that we call
the passing of the peace with those around us,
let the inclusiveness, compassion, and generosity of this place
help us give thanks on this day.
May the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition *from Psalm 8*

Claire Kelly & Juniper Fayazova

For these words of wisdom from our ancestors,
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

God of all blessings, source of all life, giver of all grace:
We thank you for the gift of life, for the breath that sustains life,
for the food of this earth that nurtures life,
for the love of family and friends without which there would be no life.

*We thank you for the mystery of creation:
for the beauty that the eye can see, for the joy that the ear may hear,
for the unknown that we cannot behold filling the universe with wonder,
for the expanse of space that draws us beyond the definitions of our selves.*

We thank you for setting us in communities:
for families who nurture our becoming,
for friends who love us by choice,
for companions at work, who share our burdens and daily tasks,
for strangers who welcome us into their midst,
for people from other lands who call us to grow in understanding,
for children who lighten our moments with delight,
for the unborn, who offer us hope for the future.

*We thank you for this day:
for life and one more day to love,*

*for opportunity and one more day to work for justice and peace,
for neighbors and one more person to love and by whom be loved,
for your grace and one more experience of your presence,
for your promise: to be with us,
to be our God, and to give us your peace.*

For these, and all blessings,
we give you thanks, Eternal, Loving God,
both this day, and in the days to come.
Amen and Amen!

-Vienna Cobb Anderson

Meditation Anthem

"Rainbow Connection"
Laude

PAUL WILLIAMS, arr. DAVID HARRIS

Sermon

The Grateful Life ~ Be Astonished

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Lehman

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Of Efi Ope Fun Oluwa"
Cathedral Choir, Molly Pease, Soloist

DAMILOLA ODEBIYI

*"O give thanks to God for God is good, and God's love endures forever. God's divinity flows with power.
God of the ancestors, you are worthy to be praised. We are grateful indeed, thank you!"*

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Rev. Lehman

Gracious God, Source of All Life,
you have been extravagant in your Generosity.
You have planted within us the seeds of Compassion.
You have nurtured within us the saplings of Hope.
You have harvested the fruits of your Creation
and spread before us the feast of all Possibility.
Words cannot express the gratitude with which
we come before you today.

May we embody our thanks with extravagant generosity.
May we offer our lives to you in acts of compassion for one another.

May we walk gently upon this earth, ever mindful of your gifts
of Breath, of Love – of Life itself.

May it be so, O God.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

The blessings of heaven,
the blessings of earth,
the blessings of sea and of sky.
On those we love this day
and on every human family
the gifts of heaven,
the gifts of earth,
the gifts of sea and sky.
[jphilipnewell]
Amen! May it be so!

Choral Response

"Gaelic Blessing"
Cathedral Choir

JOHN RUTTER

***Hymn for the Journey**

Come, See the Fullness

BUNESSAN

God the Creator gave in abundance
All of the wonder we now behold;
Colors of glory, everyday beauty,
Echo the story of God's deep love.

Bold as the sunlight, tender as nightfall,
Love shaped the heav'n's height; love filled the seas.
Love formed the flowers, called for the living;
Marked out the hours of time to be.

Come, see the fullness – Life we've been given;
Beauty and promise, mystr'y and hope.
Laughter and weeping, vision and purpose;
Friends for the keeping, strength for the road.

Open our hearts wide, teach us your wisdom
Lest our days pass by empty and small.
May we be witness with your creation –
To your great kindness given to all.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence
Allegro in G Major (John Stanley)

Inside The Music

“Damilola Odebiyi and I connected a few years ago somewhat randomly through another colleague. This week we have the special honor of premiering another one of his pieces. Dami is Nigerian, and has been honing a technique of writing in his native language of Yoruba. Though it’s not unique to him, there are very few people exploring this approach to music. Yoruba is a tonal language. As Dami described it, there are three basic pitches: a high, a middle, and a low one. In reality, there are many more affectations, but that’s the simple understanding. To hear Yoruba spoken is to listen to music. The unique approach is that Dami uses the tonality of the Yoruba language to guide his note and rhythm choices when writing. The result is a deeply integrated piece whose music reflects the music of the words. Even to those less familiar with the language, the music sings with bold clarity and structural integrity. In “Of Efi Ope Fun Oluwa” Dami draws inspiration from the Psalms to create an anthem of thanksgiving. The piece opens with a canon on “Give thanks to God.” The counterpoint and melodic choices drawn from the language begin to sound like a West African drumming ensemble to the astute listener. It is as if Dami has woven an ancestral message of gratitude into the music that is itself woven into the language of his birth. The music then makes a turn into 12/8 meter in a slow dance lilt that is common to his compositions. A soloist calls out for gratitude in a new, grand dance and the choir answers with full voices. He ends by returning to the opening music, this time with fewer canonic elements. It is now a hymn to the divine that swells and grows to its final joyful eruption. We are fortunate to have the opportunity to bring music like this to life. Because of our musical leaders, our connections around the world, and your interest in celebrating diverse and new voices, we have a chance to participate in the ever-flowing generosity of astonishment that becomes creativity in the hands of composers. We are enjoying a beautiful, meaningful gift circle that will continue to radiate outward as other people hear our recordings of his music and fall in love with them as we have. The gifts of music, of musicians, of this community, and of connections around the world create a cornucopia of possibility that our minds can scarcely fathom. I find this to be astonishingly delightful, and a gratitude well worth sharing. I’m also excited to get to share this anthem of thanks on a day when we get to say “Thank you!” to Rev. Laura for her ten years of leadership and tireless service to all of us. She has been a true gift whose presence is well worth celebrating through gratitude.” -Dr. David Harris